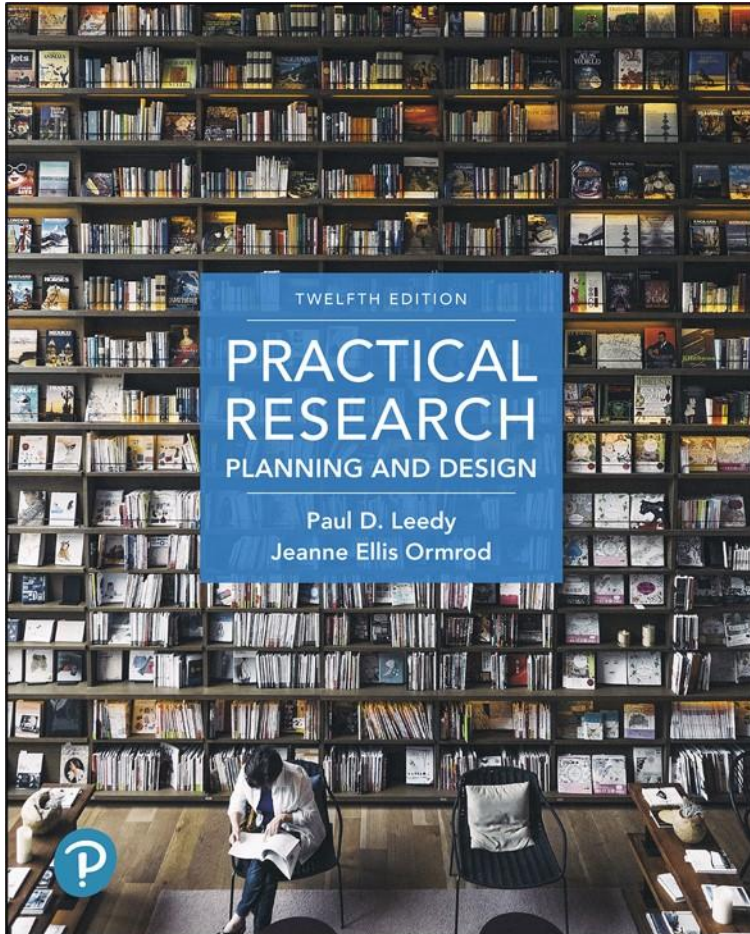


Practical Research: Planning and Design

Twelfth Edition



Chapter 5

Writing the Research Proposal

The Research Proposal

- Essential to successful research
- Includes
 - Clearly stated problem and subproblems
 - Hypotheses and/or questions
 - Precise definitions of terms
 - Carefully spelled-out limitations and delimitations
 - Explanation of the purpose of the study
 - Specific details about all aspects of data collection and interpretation

Characteristics of a Research Proposal

- Straightforward document containing only necessary information
- Conventional prose, economy of words, precision of expression
- Clearly organized
- Usually follows convention

Organization of a Quantitative Proposal

1. The problem and its setting
2. Review of related literature
3. Data and its treatment
4. Qualifications of the researcher and team
5. Study outline
6. References
7. Appendices

Organization of a Qualitative Proposal

1. Introduction
 2. Methodology
 3. Management plan, timeline, feasibility
 4. References
 5. Appendices
- Key rule for both quantitative and qualitative proposals: Information should be presented in such a manner that it leads readers clearly and logically from one facet of the research project to the next.

Formatting Headings and Subheadings

- Different formats indicate different levels of headings to be used. The American Psychological Association's Publication Manual (2010) specifies the following formats:
- Level 1: Boldface uppercase and lowercase, centered.
- Level 2: Boldface uppercase and lowercase, left-aligned.
- Level 3: Boldface first-letter-only-uppercase, ends with a period.
- Level 4: Italicized boldface first-letter-only-uppercase, ends with a period, indented at the beginning of the first paragraph in a section.
- Level 5: Italicized non-boldface first-letter-only-uppercase, ends with a period, indented at the beginning of the first paragraph in a section.

Writing Your Proposal (1 of 3)

1. Use word processing software
2. Adhere to guidelines required by the institution, organization, or funding agency to which you are submitting the proposal
3. Focus the first draft on organization and logical thought sequences rather than on exact wording, grammatical correctness, and spelling
4. Present the research problem at the beginning
5. Provide a context for the problem
6. Convince the reader of the importance of the project

Writing Your Proposal (2 of 3)

7. Assume that your reader(s) know nothing about your project
8. Communicate that you have an open mind about what you will find
9. Describe your proposed methodology with as much detail and precision as possible
10. Describe where any pre-existing data are located and how you plan to obtain them
11. Describe how you will use the data to answer your research problem

Writing Your Proposal (3 of 3)

12. Use appendices wisely

13. Be careful that you don't plagiarize other sources, even in subtle ways

Revising Your Proposal (1 of 2)

1. Set the proposal aside for a few days
2. Read a paper copy of your first draft
3. Carefully scrutinize what you have written, looking for disorganized thoughts, illogical thinking, and inconsistencies in terminology
4. Look for text that might be clearer
5. Keep sentences simple and straightforward
6. Choose words carefully
7. Check carefully for errors in grammar, punctuation, and spelling

Revising Your Proposal (2 of 2)

8. Make sure that items in bulleted lists and the like are parallel in structure
9. Make sure there is a one-to-one correspondence between citations in the text and references
10. Consider the feasibility of the project once again
11. Read a printed copy again
12. Seek the feedback of others

Look for and Correct Weaknesses (1 of 5)

- Weaknesses related to the research problem:
 - Research has unclear purpose
 - Problem is unimportant
 - Hypothesis is ill-defined or unsound
 - Problem is too complex
 - Problem has limited relevance to the field

Look for and Correct Weaknesses (2 of 5)

- Weaknesses related to the research design & methodology:
 - Description of design and method is vague and/or unfocused
 - Data inappropriate for the research problem
 - Methodology/procedures inappropriate for the research problem

Look for and Correct Weaknesses (3 of 5)

- Weaknesses related to the research design & methodology:
 - Appropriate controls lacking or inadequate
 - Equipment outdated or inappropriate
 - Statistical analysis poorly considered

Look for and Correct Weaknesses (4 of 5)

- Weaknesses related to the investigator:
 - insufficient training or experience for the proposed research
 - unfamiliar with the literature relevant for the proposed research
 - insufficient time to devote to the project

Look for and Correct Weaknesses (5 of 5)

- Weaknesses related to resources:
 - institutional setting is unfavorable for the proposed research
 - proposed use of equipment, support staff, or other resources is unrealistic

Detractions from Proposal Effectiveness (1 of 2)

- Look for and correct
 - Vague statement of the problem
 - Incompletely described methodology
 - General and cursory treatment of each subproblem
 - Phrasing of the proposal is not useful for evaluation

Detractions from Proposal Effectiveness (2 of 2)

- Look for and correct
 - Deviation of the format of the proposal from institutional guidelines
 - Failure to include cited sources
 - Incompletely or incorrectly cited sources

For a Proposal to a Funding Agency (1 of 2)

- Look for and correct if
 - The problem does not address the research area outlined by the funding agency
 - The proposal is too ambitious for the grant money available
 - Items included in the budget are disallowed by the terms of the grant

For a Proposal to a Funding Agency (2 of 2)

- Look for and correct if
 - A clear and explicit statement is lacking; the summary of the estimated costs is ambiguous and indefinite.
 - There is an unclear explanation of the relationship of the study to the purpose for which the grant is awarded

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